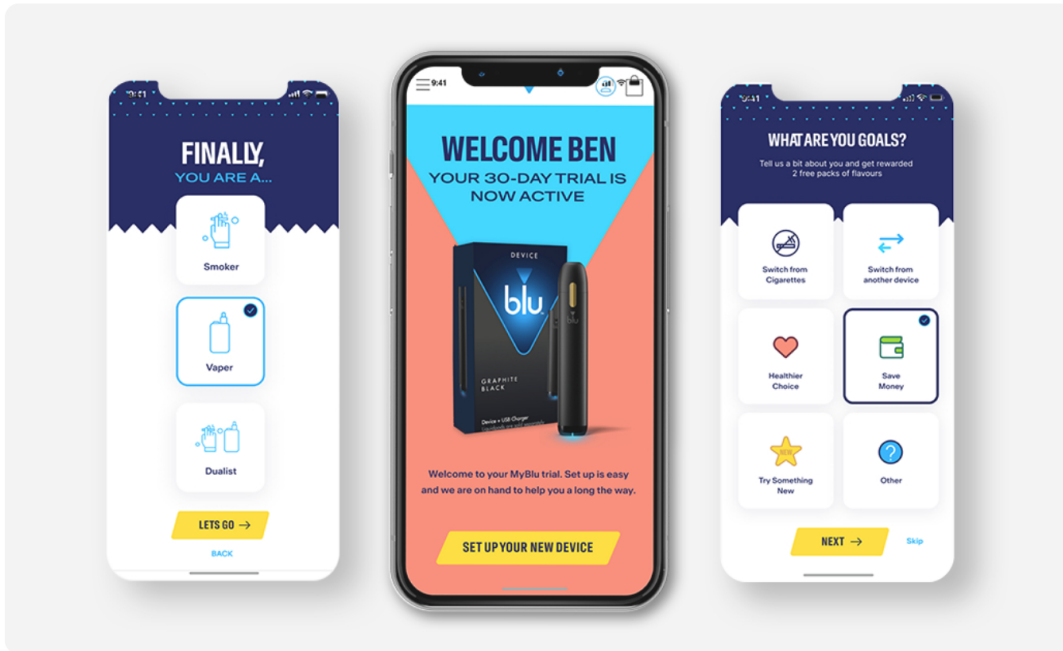




Blu Vape Brand Reimagination: A 5-Day Design Sprint

Role

UI/UX Designer

Duration

5 days (Google Design Sprint)

Team

Cross-functional Sprint Team

The Challenge

"We're losing market share to new competitors who seem to understand what customers want better than we do. Our brand feels outdated and our customer experience is fragmented."

— Marketing Director, Blu Vape

Blu Vape was experiencing declining market share driven by increased competition, shifting customer expectations, and weakening brand loyalty. Existing experiences focused heavily on products, with limited emotional connection or long-term engagement.

The challenge was to **reimagine the brand experience** and explore how Blu Vape could differentiate through customer experience, loyalty, and community—rather than competing solely on products.

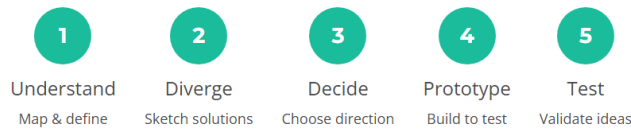
Sprint Challenge

- Declining market share and brand relevance
- Fragmented customer experience across touchpoints
- Limited product innovation and weak loyalty mechanisms
- Lack of clear competitive differentiation

Sprint Goals

Over a 5-day Google Design Sprint, we aimed to rapidly explore, prototype, and validate a new product concept and customer journey that could strengthen Blu Vape's market presence and deepen customer engagement.

5-Day Sprint Process



1 Day 1: Understand – Mapping the Challenge

Sprint goal: Build a shared understanding of the problem space by aligning business objectives, brand direction, and user needs.

I worked closely with stakeholders to understand Blu Vape's vision, rebranding ambitions, and commercial challenges. In parallel, we mapped the end-to-end customer journey and reviewed competitor approaches to loyalty, trial, and retail engagement.

"Our customers don't just buy products—they want to be part of a community. We need to create experiences that build relationships, not just transactions."

— Customer Experience Lead, Sprint Team

Sprint Day 1 Activities

Stakeholder Interviews: I facilitated lightning talks with key stakeholders to clarify business goals, brand direction, and sprint success criteria.

Customer Journey Mapping: We mapped the existing customer journey from awareness to loyalty, identifying gaps, friction points, and emotional drop-offs.

Competitive Analysis: We analysed competitor strategies around loyalty programmes, trial mechanics, and tobacconist partnerships to identify opportunities for differentiation.

Problem Definition: I synthesised insights into clear problem statements and sprint objectives that guided decision-making throughout the week.

Sprint Documentation

I documented stakeholder insights and journey mapping to establish a shared foundation for the sprint team.

Stakeholder Insights



Stakeholder interview synthesis

Customer Journey Map



Customer journey mapping

Brand Differentiation

Create a product experience that clearly sets Blu Vape apart from competitors

Customer Retention

Design touchpoints that build trust and long-term loyalty

Brand Alignment

Ensure the experience aligns with Blu Vape's refreshed brand identity and values

2 Day 2: Diverge – Exploring Wide-Ranging Solutions

Sprint goal: Generate a wide range of potential solutions before narrowing down, ensuring we explored bold ideas without premature constraints.

We ran collaborative ideation sessions focused on loyalty, product trial, and tobacco engagement. All ideas were sketched individually to avoid groupthink before being shared and clustered.

Sprint Ideation Process

I facilitated a **Crazy 8s** session followed by detailed concept sketching. Each team member worked independently, then we reviewed and discussed ideas as a group.

Individual Sketching Session

Ideas ranged from digital loyalty systems and community features to in-store trial experiences and retailer tools. The emphasis was on **volume and variety**, not refinement.



Crazy 8s ideation sketches

Thematic Clustering

I grouped ideas into strategic themes to identify patterns and opportunities for cohesive solutions:

- Brand Identity
- Product Innovation
- Customer Experience

Concept Clustering

I documented the clustering process to guide convergence decisions on Day 3.



Thematic clustering of ideas

Key Solution Themes Emerged

Customer Loyalty

Personalised rewards, exclusive benefits, and community features to drive retention and advocacy.

Product Trial

Starter kits and sampling concepts to reduce barriers for new users.

Retail Partnerships

Tools and resources to support tobacco retailers and strengthen retail relationships.

3 Day 3: Decide – Converging on the Best Direction

Sprint goal: Evaluate concepts objectively and align on a single direction to prototype.

We reviewed all sketches using dot voting and an evaluation matrix that considered **user value, business impact, and feasibility**. Final decisions were made by the sprint decider, informed by team input.

Winning Concept: Integrated Loyalty Ecosystem

We selected a concept centred on an **integrated loyalty ecosystem** that connected digital experiences with physical touchpoints and emphasised community and personalisation.

- Tiered loyalty rewards
- Curated starter kits
- Community features for engagement
- Tobacco retailer partnership portal
- Exclusive member experiences
- Integrated feedback loops



Decision matrix and concept selection

4 Day 4: Prototype – Building to Learn

Sprint goal: Create a realistic prototype to test our core assumptions without building the full product.

I led the design of mid- and high-fidelity prototypes, focusing on three critical flows: **product discovery, loyalty onboarding, and community engagement.**

Prototype Development Strategy

My focus was on building *just enough fidelity* to test both usability and emotional response to the reimagined brand. We prioritised clarity, flow, and brand tone over exhaustive screen coverage.

Mid-Fidelity Wireframes

I started with wireframes to validate information architecture and user flows, ensuring the loyalty ecosystem concept made sense before adding visual polish.



Mid-fidelity wireframes

High-Fidelity Prototype

I then created a polished prototype reflecting the refreshed brand direction. This allowed users to experience the proposed ecosystem as a cohesive product rather than isolated features.

Key Prototype Areas

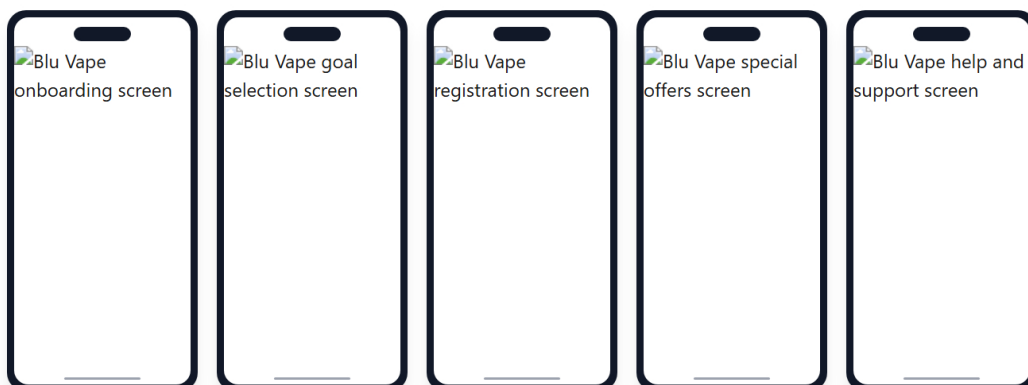
Trial onboarding

Goal selection

Registration

Special offers

Help & support



Prototype Testing Scenarios

We defined three scenarios to validate our core assumptions:

New User Onboarding

Testing starter kit selection and loyalty sign-up

Loyalty Engagement

Evaluating rewards and community appeal

Retail Integration

Testing tobacconist value proposition and tools

5 Day 5: Test – Validating with Real Users

Sprint goal: Validate assumptions with real users and determine next steps.

We conducted moderated testing sessions with **8 participants** across three groups: existing customers, potential new users, and tobacconist representatives. Each participant completed a 45-minute session covering key flows, combining behavioural observation with qualitative feedback.

Strong Positive Response

- 87% found the loyalty programme appealing
- 100% of new users understood and valued the starter kits
- 75% expressed interest in community features
- All tobacconists valued the centralised resource hub

Areas for Improvement

- Simplify reward redemption
- Clarify community guidelines
- Improve mobile flow performance
- Strengthen onboarding guidance

User Insights

"This finally feels like a brand that understands what I want, not just trying to sell me products."

"The starter kit makes it easy to try without committing."

"Having centralised resources makes me more confident in promoting the brand."

Sprint Conclusions & Impact

This 5-day sprint allowed us to explore bold new directions and validate them quickly with real users. The outcome demonstrated a clear opportunity for Blu Vape to differentiate through **experience, loyalty, and community**, rather than product features alone. The sprint compressed months of exploration into one focused week and delivered a validated strategic direction for brand reimagination.

Recommended Next Steps

- Refine the prototype based on testing feedback
- Define technical requirements for development
- Plan a phased rollout of loyalty features
- Launch a pilot with selected tobacconist partners
- Establish success metrics and feedback loops
- Run follow-up sprints for individual features

Sprint Reflection

This project reinforced the value of the Google Design Sprint in aligning stakeholders, accelerating decision-making, and validating ideas quickly. By focusing on customer experience rather than product differentiation alone, we uncovered a clear path forward for Blu Vape's brand transformation.

The strongest validation came from a stakeholder who said:

"This sprint gave us the confidence and direction we needed to move forward with a

complete brand transformation."

